



Music therapy

Singer and dancer Lola Falana performs for American servicemen in Da Nang as part of the Bob Hope Christmas tour in 1970. Hope entertained the troops in Vietnam every Christmas from 1964 to 1972.

R&R centers

The military also provided US troops with respite from the war through a robust R&R program. It built dozens of stand-down R&R centers across South Vietnam. These were standard bases with extra amenities into which combat units rotated while on break from combat. They included the “Tay Ninh Holiday Inn” and “Waikiki East.” The military also built two in-country R&R centers at China Beach and Vung Tau, resorts with long sandy beaches, offering hotel services such as clean sheets and towels, and ceiling fans. The most popular R&R option, however, was out-of-country R&R, which provided the greatest contrast with the war. Soldiers were able to indulge themselves with food, drink, sex workers, and shopping for five days. At the peak of the R&R program, troops on leave could visit one of nine destinations on the Pacific Rim, including Bangkok, Hong Kong, and Sydney. Hawaii was the most popular out-of-country option, providing home comforts plus the chance to spend time with family.